BEST Management Advice

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"FAILURE IS TEMPORARY, BUT GIVING UP IS FINAL"



Q You started Biocon at 25, at a time when being young and a woman made it harder to be taken seriously. What did you do in those early years to build credibility and earn trust, and what can young women managers learn from that?

When I started Biocon at 25, I had no business experience, little capital and the added challenge of being a young woman in a field few understood. Banks refused to lend, customers were sceptical, and even recruiting employees was difficult. Instead of giving up, I focused relentlessly on competence and delivery, supplying high-quality products on time, and doing what I said I would do. Sheer resilience, self-belief, and proven results helped me earn trust. Performance, in the end, builds credibility.

Q What specific habits or skills should young managers build early in their careers?

Credibility begins with confidence and competence. In my own early years, what helped me enormously was my deep technical knowledge of fermentation science. When I met customers, I could understand their technical challenges and engage with them on how to solve them. They realised that I was not there simply to sell a product, but to bring knowledge and solutions to the table. That earned me trust and credibility.

For young managers, I would say: be dependable, deliver on your commitments and focus on the value you create. You don't always need formal authority to lead. When people respect your contribution and trust you to deliver, leadership follows.

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Q As women move into middle and senior management, they are often expected to deliver results while also navigating stereotypes about how women should lead. What advice would you give them?

Leadership starts with believing in yourself. You need clarity of thought, confidence in your convictions, and courage to make decisions. I have always believed authenticity is a strength. Do not try to fit someone else's idea of a leader. Focus on creating impact. Be assertive, strategic, and empathetic. Let your decisions, your actions and your results speak for you.

Q What is one piece of management advice you would give to someone looking to build a successful company?

Failure is temporary, but giving up is final. What matters is how you respond. Learn, adapt and keep moving. I have found perseverance often matters more than brilliance. BT

Biocon Ltd is an Indian biopharmaceutical company

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